The designation of Iran as China's "strategic partner" was significant. Since forming its first "strategic partnership" with Russia in 1996, China had formed such partnerships with several score mid-range powers: India, Mexico, Canada, France, Brazil, and so on. With Iran, however, China employed a carefully constructed circumlocution; the China–Iran relation was described as a "21st century oriented long-term and wide-ranging relation of friendship and cooperation in the strategic interests of the two countries."[11] Resorting to such a cumbersome circumlocution was a manifestation of Beijing's effort to balance between Tehran and Washington and was intended to limit China's commitment to support Tehran in its confrontations with the United States, a core element of Beijing's effort to balance between Washington and Tehran.[12] In the 2016 declaration, however, with the United States itself pushing for détente with the IRI, China finally committed itself to a "strategic partnership" with Iran. In the 2016 joint declaration, China supported Iran's "increasing role in regional and international affairs," while Iran reiterated "its strong commitment to [China's] One-China policy." Implicitly, that put the two powers in joint opposition to the United States. Iran welcomed China's Silk Road proposals, and both sides declared preparedness for expanded cooperation in transportation, railways, and ports, among other sectors.

China's willingness to undertake port development projects in Iran also marked an incremental shift in Chinese policy. While China had built, financed, and/or operated at least ten ports in Indian Ocean littoral countries in the 1990s and 2000s, it had avoided undertaking major port development efforts in Iran.[13] The 2016 Joint Declaration suggested that China would start cooperating in port development as part of the expanded partnership with Iran. Security and defence were also areas of expanded China–Iranian cooperation identified by the January 2016 joint declaration. The armed forces of the two countries would expand cooperation in